Activity

What's with all the Pressure?

Students learn how to take blood pressure by observing a teacher demonstration and then practicing on fellow classmates in small groups. Once the hands-on component of this activity is completed, the class brainstorms and discusses how blood pressure might affect a person's health.

Learning Objectives

- Describe the tools used to measure blood pressure.
- Measure a persons blood pressure using appropriate equipment.
- Describe how blood pressure is measured with a sphygmomanometer, which gives a reading of systolic over diastolic pressure in units of mmHG (millimeters of mercury).

Measuring Blood Pressure Worksheet

1. Place the blood pressure cuff on the upper arm of the student volunteer "patient" (if clothing is very thick, you may need to ask them to roll up their sleeve). You want the bottom of the cuff to be just above their elbow
2. Place the stethoscope so that it is between the patient's skin and the blood pressure cuff. You want to place it just above the elbow, on the inside of the arm-on the inside crook of the arm. This way, it is placed over the brachial artery
3. Tighten the cuff around the patient's arm and stethoscope so that is it snug, but not tight.
4. Make sure the relief valve (the screw knob attached to the bulb of the blood pressure cuff) is completely closed, and press the bulb several times until the dial on the cuff reads 200
5. While listening through the stethoscope, slowly turn the relief valve so that some air escapes at a slow but steady rate. You should not hear any pulse in the stethoscope yet, and you should note that the needle on the dial is slowly going down.
6. Continue to release air and listen until you first hear a pulse through the stethoscope. Mentally record the number the needle is on when you first hear the sound. This number is the patient's systolic pressure.
7. Continue to release air and listen, this time until the pulse sound goes completely away. The number that the needle is on when the sound stops is the patient's diastolic pressure.
8. Record both numbers below. Release any residual air from the cuff, and remove it and the stethoscope from the patient.

Record Results

Student #1 Name.....

Systolic Pressure..... Diastolic Pressure.....

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